

» TOURNAMENT WRAP PRIME VOLLEYBALL LEAGUE

Strike force: Averaging 12.22 points per game, Bengaluru Torpedoes' Joel Benjamin (5) ended the campaign with an attacking success rate of 56.7 per cent. **Facing page:** David Lee (centre) celebrates with his team.

REDEMPTION SERVED HOT

After a string of near-misses, former Olympic medallist David Lee finally finds success in the Prime Volleyball League as Bengaluru Torpedoes **outgunned** Mumbai Meteors in the final.

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Former American volleyball player David Lee's time in the Prime Volleyball League is filled with stories of almost-glory.

During the inaugural season in 2022, he bowed out in the semifinals while playing for Calicut Heroes. In the following two seasons, the two-time Olympic medallist swapped the court for the sidelines, coaching the Bengaluru Torpedoes and guiding it to a final and a semifinal, only to meet the same cruel fate on both occasions.

So, this season, when Mumbai Meteors' Nikhil miscued his serve on Bengaluru's championship point, for Lee, it wasn't just a title, but a well-earned redemption.

Lee's men had played second fiddle to the Meteors for much of the tournament, even losing when the two sides met in the group stage. The Matt Van Wezel-coached Meteors

dropped just one of their six group-stage matches.

To add to its feat, in their run to the final, the team lost only seven sets while winning 22. In contrast, the Torpedoes and season two champion Ahmedabad were the only other teams to register a positive set difference among the remaining nine competitors.

However, ahead of the final, Lee insisted that his side needed to be aggressive to break down his counterpart's cohesive unit.

"Our team has been fairly aggressive throughout the years — not just this season, but in the past as well. So, for us, it's just about coming out and winning the serve-and-pass game. If we serve aggressively, we can take control of the match," Lee said.

This approach worked quite well, helping the Torpedoes overwhelm their opponent in straight sets and clinch their maiden title.

Power game

Lee's combative approach was

well complemented by his players, especially 22-year-old Joel Benjamin. The youngster, brought in from Chennai Blitz in the auction, led the attack with authority and topped the charts for most points scored, with 115 in nine matches.

Averaging 12.22 points per game, Benjamin ended the campaign with an attacking success rate of 56.7 per cent, earning the Best Attacker of the Season award. To sweeten the victory, he was also adjudged Most Valuable Player of the Season, becoming the fourth consecutive Indian to win the honour.

While Benjamin handled the offence, from behind the end line it was the experienced Sethu T. R. who troubled opponents with his serve. His league-leading 13 points earned him the Best Server label for the second season running.

Moreover, the Torpedoes were among the most effective users of the league's unique innovations — the Super Serve and Super Points. They amassed a combined 29 points